Heinrich Khunrath — Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae (1595 / 1609)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Heinrich Khunrath, the Leipzig-born physician who joined medicine, alchemy, and theology in a single search for divine wisdom. He built his *Amphitheatre of Eternal Wisdom* around 365 scriptural verses and nine engravings, among them the oratory-laboratory, where prayer and laboratory work share one room. Antoine Faivre credited the book with inaugurating a theosophy of the image, a way of teaching through pictures as much as through prose. Khunrath did not live to see his work complete: he died in 1605, and the expanded Hanau edition that gives the book its full form appeared only in 1609. His pictures have travelled widely ever since, while the text that explains them has had almost no life in English. This presentation is dedicated to the physician who made the book, and to the words that belong with its images.

The story

Heinrich Khunrath (c. 1560–1605) was a Leipzig-born Paracelsian physician and theosopher — a physician in the tradition of Paracelsus, and a thinker who joined medicine, alchemy, and theology in a single search for divine wisdom. His *Amphitheatrum Sapientiae Aeternae*, the "Amphitheatre of Eternal Wisdom," is a theosophical commentary built around 365 scriptural verses and nine famous

engravings: four circular "hieroglyphic" figures and five rectangular plates, including the well-known oratory-laboratory plate, which shows prayer and laboratory work in one room. Antoine Faivre credited the book with inaugurating a "theosophy of the image" — a way of teaching through pictures as much as through prose.

The book appeared twice in Khunrath's world. It was first issued at Hamburg in 1595 in a small, high-status edition, and then, after his death, in the expanded Hanau edition of 1609, which is the complete form. The pictures travelled. The plates have been reproduced again and again, and readers who know nothing else of Khunrath often know the oratory-laboratory image. The text that surrounds and explains those images has had a narrower life, and in English, as the record below shows, it has effectively had none.

The work and what survives

Both editions survive. Copies are held and digitised by major special collections, among them the University of Wisconsin–Madison copy of the 1595 edition, from the Duveen collection. A reviewer's check for this collection pins the full 1609 text scan on Internet Archive as `amphitheatrvmsap00khun`, linked from the Houghton copy record, and records the complete 1595 edition digitised at UW–Madison: four plates and 24 pages of text. The Science History Institute digitises the plates only, which is not a translation base by itself. The work is in the public domain: the imprints are 1595 and 1609, and the author died in 1605.

Its English fortunes

A scholarly esotericism site states flatly that there is no available scholarly English translation of the work. The first full translation tradition reported here is French: Émile-Jules Grillot de Givry's, made for René Philipon's Bibliothèque Rosicrucienne (1898). A reviewer's check adds that a complete translation exists in Czech (Hlaváček, Prague, 2017), so English is the gap, not translation itself. Forshaw's four-volume *The Mage's Images* (Brill, 2024–25) is a study, not a translation. Enthusiasts, meanwhile, are reduced to posting home-made working translations of excerpts from the French.

The finding must be stated at its true strength, because no catalogue census was run for this title: **No English translation, complete or scholarly, found in the sources consulted below (an enthusiast site, a ResearchGate record, and an auction listing; no WorldCat or edition-graph census was run for this title).**

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean translation from the 1609 Latin — dense, idiosyncratic theosophical Latin interwoven with German. A sensible order would take the prose commentary on the grades and verses first, with the plates' captions and inscriptions as a companion instalment, since the plates are the famous part and their lettering is integral text. The review standard set for it is a Latinist familiar with early-modern alchemy.

It is smaller than some works in this collection, but harder per page. The difficulty warning carried from the reviewer should stand in full: the text is polyglot — Latin, Greek, and Hebrew — with coined compound neologisms, and it is the hardest text in the survey.

Sources

- https://via-hygeia.art/heinrich-khunrath-from-the-amphitheatrum-sapientiae-aeternae-about-divine-wisdom/ (states no scholarly English translation exists; French of Grillot de Givry, 1898; UW–Madison copy)
- https://www.researchgate.net/publication/304680889 (Forshaw/Tilton scholarship on Khunrath; 1595/1609 edition history)
- https://www.lot-art.com/auction-lots/KHUNRATH-Heinrich-Amphitheatrum-sapientiae-aeternae-soliu/138-khunrath_heinrich-11.2.25-bado (1609 edition description, plate census)
- https://www.library.wisc.edu/specialcollections/collections/history-of-science/khunraths-amphitheatrum-sapientiae-aeternae-1595/
- https://digital.sciencehistory.org/works/dodh36q
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